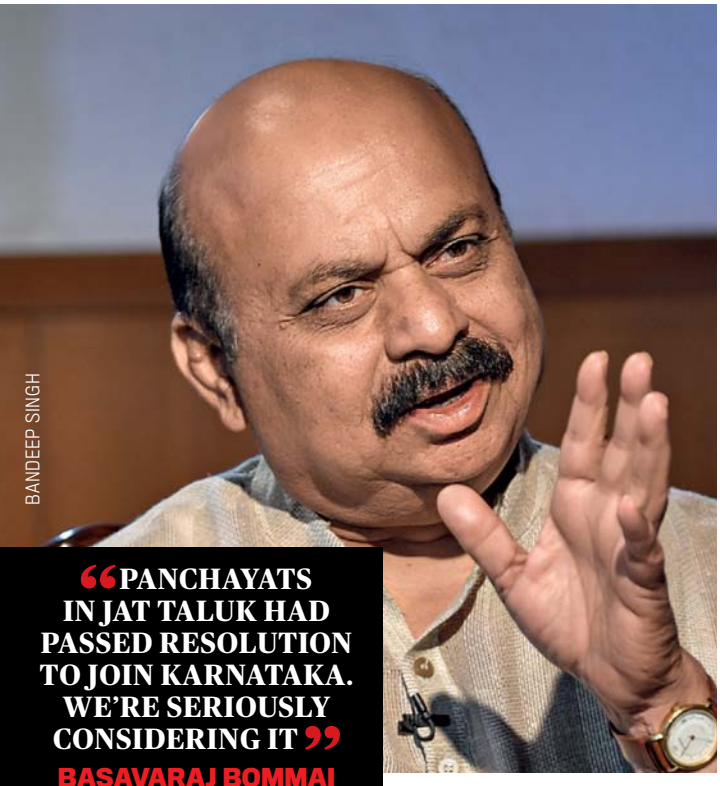
KARNATAKA/ MAHARASHTRA

Battle for Belagavi

By Ajay Sukumaran



BANDEEP SINGH

"PANCHAYATS IN JAT TALUK HAD PASSED RESOLUTION TO JOIN KARNATAKA. WE'RE SERIOUSLY CONSIDERING IT"

BASAVARAJ BOMMAI
Chief Minister, Karnataka



ANI

"THE STATE GOVERNMENT IS DETERMINED TO GET JUSTICE FOR EVERY BROTHER IN THE BORDER AREAS"

EKNATH SHINDE
Chief Minister, Maharashtra

As disputes between states go, the row over Belagavi (formerly Belgaum) has a life of its own. Simmering for decades, it periodically froths over—like it did last December and the year before, with many iterations going back in time to India's state reorganisation on linguistic grounds beginning in the mid-1950s. On all occasions, tensions had risen temporarily in the border district that belongs to Karnataka but which Maharashtra has, for decades, claimed as its territory—on the emotive grounds that it has a significant population of Marathi speakers. It has resurfaced this year too, amid an explosion of rhetoric that had the biggest political players on both sides weighing in, with everyone girding up ahead of Supreme Court proceedings.

In Maharashtra, Chief Minister Eknath Shinde met an all-party panel on the border dispute and even promised to extend the CM's relief fund coverage and freedom fighter pensions to families that were involved in the decades-long revanchist struggle. The 'provocation' got an equally sharp response, for Belagavi is an equally emotive issue for Kannada speakers. All border disputes, retorted Shinde's Karnataka counterpart Basavaraj Bommai, had ended with the States' Reorganisation Act in 1956. But since there's a lawsuit in court, Karnataka's top